

The Seed Sovereignty Guide

What they patented, what remains free, and how to build a seed library that no corporation can touch

HOW SEED PATENTS WORK

- Large agri-corporations (Bayer/Monsanto, Corteva, Syngenta) hold patents on specific plant varieties including some GMO and conventionally bred hybrids.
- Replanting patented seeds without a license is infringement - this affects commercial farmers who sign technology agreements, not home gardeners.
- Key ruling: *Bowman v. Monsanto* (2013, US Supreme Court) confirmed that patent exhaustion does not apply to seeds - every generation of a patented seed requires a new license.
- What you can save freely: any open-pollinated (OP), heirloom, or public-domain variety. If the packet says 'OP' or 'heirloom', save away.

SEED TYPES EXPLAINED

- Open-pollinated (OP): pollinated by wind, insects, or hand. Seeds breed true to type - the child plant resembles the parent. These are what you save.
- Heirloom: OP varieties passed down for at least 50 years (some for centuries). Superior flavor. Always saveable.
- Hybrid (F1): crossing two parent lines produces uniform crops but unstable next-generation seeds. Not worth saving.
- GMO: patented, not available to home gardeners through normal channels.

SAVING BY CROP TYPE

- Tomatoes: self-pollinating. Scoop seeds into water, ferment 2-3 days, rinse, dry flat. Ready in 1-2 weeks.
- Beans & peas: let pods dry fully on the plant until brown and rattling, then shell and dry indoors 2 weeks more.
- Peppers: self-pollinating. Let fruit fully ripen (past eating stage), scrape seeds onto paper, air dry 2 weeks.
- Corn: needs 200+ plants for genetic diversity. Let ears dry on stalk until husk is fully papery, then shell.
- Squash & cucumbers: need 500-foot isolation from other varieties. Scoop, ferment briefly, rinse, dry flat.
- Lettuce: let it bolt and go to seed. Shake seed heads into a bag when tips turn white and fluffy.

DRY STORAGE - 1 TO 5 YEAR LONGEVITY

- Moisture is the enemy. Seeds must be dry enough to shatter when bent, not bend.
- Container: small glass jars with tight lids, or paper envelopes inside a sealed glass jar with silica gel packet. Never plastic bags long-term.
- Location: cool, dark, dry. A fridge works well. Consistent temperature matters more than extreme cold.
- Label everything immediately: variety name, date saved, source plant notes. You will not remember in February.
- Viability by type: onions 1yr; sweet corn 2yr; beans/peas 3yr; tomatoes/peppers 4yr; squash/cucumbers 5yr.

SEED SWAPS & COMMUNITY LIBRARIES

- Seed Savers Exchange (seedsavers.org): largest heirloom seed library in the US, thousands of varieties.
- Baker Creek Heirloom Seeds (rareseeds.com): no hybrids, no GMO, no patents.

- Local seed libraries: many county public libraries now run free seed libraries. Check yours.
- Neighbor-to-neighbor swaps: the best seeds are already adapted to your exact microclimate.

>> THE SAGE'S TIP: Save seeds from three plants minimum of each variety. One plant's seeds are a monoculture. Three plants' seeds are a beginning.

The seed your grandfather saved was a vote against dependency. Every seed you save is the same vote. - The Sage

